



THE APERTURE METHOD™ · CLASSROOM PROGRAM

Look Closer

A 50-minute introduction to how a business really works

*The question this answers: **What is actually holding this business back?***

PREPARED FOR

Grades 8–12

The Woodlands, Texas

Facilitator Guide · Edition One · The Aperture Method™

A NOTE ON THE BUSINESSES — Every business in this packet is invented. The streets, parks and shopping centers are real places in The Woodlands, Texas, so the exercise feels like home — but no real business is described, and no real numbers are used.

START HERE

The one thing they leave with

"I could actually do this."

That is the takeaway. Not a framework, not a definition, not a worksheet they will have lost by Friday. One belief, in the student's own voice.

A single class period cannot teach a skill — skills need practice. What a single period CAN do is change what a student believes is available to them. Everything in this packet — the lenses, the cards, the arithmetic — exists to manufacture the evidence for that one sentence. A student who spends fifteen minutes looking at a business, finds the thing that is wrong with it, and turns out to be right is holding proof that cannot be argued with, because they produced it themselves.

You cannot give a teenager that feeling with a speech. You can only let them earn it. That is why you talk for twelve minutes and they work for twenty-three, and why anything that eats into their twenty-three should be cut — including your own good stories.

The three ideas underneath it

1. Every business has one thing holding it back. Find that one thing and you can fix the whole business. It is true of a lemonade stand, a barbershop, and a company with four thousand employees.
2. Being busy and making money are not the same thing. Most adults have never separated these two, which is why the lawn crew card lands so hard.
3. You find the answer by counting, not by being a genius. Counting is free, it takes no talent, and almost nobody does it.

Three. Not five, not eight. If you catch yourself adding a fourth on the day, cut it instead — the number of things a room remembers does not go up when you say more of them.

Who it is aimed at

Aim this at future entrepreneurs and you are talking to about three students in the room. The rest decided that was not them years ago and will check out in the first four minutes.

Aim it at everyone who will spend their life inside a business — working in one, managing one, buying from one — and you have all thirty. The founders still come out of it. They come out better, because they learned to look before they learned to pitch.

What this session is not

It is not a talk about how great it is to be an entrepreneur. Students are drowning in that message already and most of it is not true.

It is not a pitch competition. Pitching rewards the most confident person in the room; this session rewards the one who noticed.

It is not about your career. You get four minutes at the end, and only after they have done real work.

Why it is built around a bottleneck

The instinct every person has about a struggling business is "they need to advertise more." It is almost always wrong, and it is wrong in an interesting way — it treats the visible symptom as the cause. Five of the six business cards in this packet have a bottleneck that advertising would make worse, not better. One of them, deliberately, does not.

By the end of the hour a student should be able to look at a business and ask a better question than "how do we get more customers?" They should ask "what happens to the customers we already get?"

THE FRAMEWORK

The five lenses

Write these on the board before students arrive. Leave them up the whole session. Students will refer to them constantly, and the physical act of looking up at the board is what turns a list into a habit.

Lens	The question a student asks	What a bad answer looks like
WHO	Who actually buys this — and do they come back?	Lots of people come in. (How many come back?)
MONEY	What comes in, what goes out, what is left?	We are really busy. (Busy is not the same as paid.)
THE THING	What are we selling, and how many can we make?	People love it. (Can you make enough of it?)
WHO DOES THE WORK	Who is needed — and what happens if they are gone?	Everyone works hard. (Can anyone else do the hard part?)
WHERE & WHEN	Where are we, and are we open when people want us?	Great location. (Open at the right hours?)

The rule that makes it work

A team must name ONE bottleneck. Not three. Not "a few things." One.

This will frustrate some students, which is correct — it is the same frustration a real executive feels, and the discipline of choosing is the actual skill being taught.

THE SESSION

Run of show

Minutes	Segment	What happens
0 – 5	The hook	Two businesses on the same street. Which makes more money? Nobody can tell.
5 – 12	The five lenses	The bottleneck idea, taught with one example students already understand.
12 – 27	The work	Teams of 3–4 get a business card. Find the one thing holding it back.
27 – 35	Share-out	Each team gets 60 seconds. Bottleneck, evidence, fix.
35 – 45	The payoff	You reveal what each fix is worth in dollars a year.
45 – 50	The close	This is a real job. Three things to start doing this week.

0 – 5 • The hook

Do not introduce yourself yet. Start cold.

"There are two coffee shops on Six Pines Drive, about four hundred feet apart. Same street, same customers, same prices, same size. One of them made \$240,000 last year. The other one lost money and closed in March. Standing on the sidewalk looking at them, could you tell which was which?"

Take three or four guesses. Students will say things like "the one with better coffee" or "the one with more parking." Accept all of them without judgment, then land it:

"Neither of those was it. And here is the thing — the owners could not tell either. That is what I actually do for a living. Somebody's life savings is inside a building and they cannot see what is wrong with it. In about twenty minutes, you are going to do it."

If you want a local hook instead: any shopping center in The Woodlands where one storefront has turned over three times in five years while its neighbor has been there since 2009. Students know these buildings.

5 – 12 • The five lenses

Teach the bottleneck idea with one example, not five. Use the drive-thru:

"A fast-food place has a line out to the street. So they hire a second cashier. Line gets longer. Why?"

Somebody will get it: there is one fryer. Every car is waiting on the fryer, not the cashier. Now say the sentence that carries the rest of the hour:

Working on anything that is not the bottleneck changes nothing at all.

Then walk the five lenses on the board. Ninety seconds each, no more. Give one concrete example per lens and move on — this segment is a map, not a lecture. If you are still talking at minute 13, you have taken time from the part that actually teaches.

12 – 27 · The work

Teams of 3 or 4. Every team gets one business card and one worksheet per student. Say exactly this:

"You have fifteen minutes. Everything you need is on the card. Name ONE bottleneck, point to the fact that proves it, and tell me what you would do about it. You will have sixty seconds to convince us."

What you do during these fifteen minutes

- Circulate. Do not sit down. A facilitator sitting down ends the energy in a room.
- Never confirm or deny an answer. When a team asks "is it the price?", say: "What on the card makes you think that?" Every time. Without exception.
- At minute 7, call out: "Halfway. If you have three ideas, cut it to one."
- At minute 12, call out: "Three minutes. Decide who is talking."

If a team is stuck

Do not give them the answer. Give them a number to compute. "What is the profit on one of those?" or "How many can they make in an hour?" A stuck team is almost always a team that has not multiplied anything yet.

27 – 35 · Share-out

Sixty seconds a team, timed out loud. Three things only: the bottleneck, the fact that proves it, the fix. Cut them off warmly at sixty. The constraint is a gift — it stops the confident student from filling four minutes.

Write each team's bottleneck on the board as they say it. By the end you will have six different answers up there, which sets up the payoff perfectly.

Order matters

Take Kickback Sneakers LAST. Five cards will have taught the room that "advertise more" is the lazy answer. Then card six arrives and advertising is genuinely right. That reversal is the most valuable eight seconds of the session — the answer depends on the evidence, not on the reflex.

35 – 45 · The payoff

This is where numbers stop being homework. Go card by card and put the annual figure on the board next to each team's bottleneck. Use the answer key.

\$25,000

A \$600 waffle iron

\$23,400

Zero extra ad spend

\$37,000

Unlocking a door

Then say what those numbers actually mean, because a teenager has no reference point for \$37,000:

"That is a person's whole salary. That is a car, in cash, every year. And the entire idea was: open on Saturday."

The lawn crew card deserves an extra ninety seconds on its own. Put both versions on the board side by side — eight customers at \$35, seven customers at \$45 — and ask the room which business they would rather own. Fewer customers, same money, an hour of Saturday back. Most students have never been told that a smaller number can be the better answer.

45 – 50 • The close

This is the only part of the hour where the exact words matter more than the activity. Say this first — before your bio, before the careers talk, before anything:

"Fifteen minutes ago, not one of you had ever looked at a business. Then you found the thing that was wrong with one, and you were right. The person who owns that business could not see it — and they have been standing inside it every day for six years. Whatever you thought this stuff was, it is not that. It is looking carefully at something ordinary. You can do that."

Then stop talking for a second. That pause does more work than anything else in the session.

Now your four minutes on the job itself, and then three things for them to do. Make them write these down:

1. Notice. Next time you are in a store, count something. How many people in line. How many walked out. How long you waited. Counting is the entire job and it is free.
2. Ask. Find an adult who runs something — a manager, a shop owner, a parent — and ask: what is the one thing that would make this better? Then ask why it has not happened. The second question is where the truth is.
3. Count. Pick anything you could sell. Work out what it costs you and what you would charge. If those two numbers are close together, you do not have a business yet — you have a hobby with extra steps.

What to say about the job itself

People are paid to do this. The titles are analyst, consultant, operations manager, strategist, data analyst. It is a real career and most students have never heard it described.

What to take in school: every math class you can get, statistics if it is offered, economics, and — this surprises people — writing. Finding the answer is half the job. Getting a grown adult to act on it is the

other half, and that half is writing and talking.

You do not need to be the loudest person in the room. This job rewards the person who noticed the number nobody else looked at.

FIELD NOTES

Running the room

The answers you will hear, and what to do

What a student says	What to say back
"They should advertise more."	"What happens to the customers they already get?" Then wait. Do not fill the silence.
"They should lower the price."	"Walk me through it — how much more do they have to sell to make the same money?" Make them do the arithmetic. They will change their mind on their own.
"They need a bigger place."	"Are they turning people away because of space, or because of something else? Point me to the line on the card."
"Social media."	Fine for card six. For the others: "Would more people showing up make this better or worse?" On the waffle card, more people makes it worse.
"Fire someone."	Take it seriously, do not flinch. "Which one, and what stops happening when they are gone?" Usually the answer collapses on contact.
"I don't know."	"You do not have to know. Pick the number on the card that looks strangest to you and read it out loud." That is almost always enough.

If the room is dead

Abandon the team structure. Put Waterway Waffle Co. on the projector and do it as one group, out loud, with you holding the marker. Ask for one fact at a time. It works because the answer is physical — one machine, four minutes — and a quiet room can find it. Once they have solved one, teams usually come alive for a second card.

If one student dominates

Announce at the start of share-out that the person presenting cannot be the person who did the most talking in the group. Say it lightly. It redistributes the room without singling anyone out.

If you are running short

Cut the share-out to three teams and go straight to the payoff. Never cut the work time — the fifteen minutes of students arguing about a card is the only part of this session that does anything.

ADAPTING IT

Variants

40 minutes (a short period)

Hook 4 · lenses 6 · work 12 · share-out 6 · payoff 8 · close 4. Hand out only cards 1, 3, 4 and 5, doubling up so two teams work the same card — competing answers on the same business makes a better share-out anyway.

90 minutes (a block period)

Run it as written, then add a second round: teams swap cards and have to argue AGAINST the previous team's bottleneck. Ten minutes of that teaches more scepticism than an hour of lecture. Finish with the lawn crew pricing debate as a whole-class exercise.

Grades 7–8

- Use three lenses only: WHO, MONEY, THE THING.
- Use cards 1, 3 and 5. They are the most physical and the arithmetic is the cleanest.
- Pre-fill the first row of the math table on the worksheet so nobody stalls on how to start.
- Extend the work time to 18 minutes and shorten the payoff. Younger students need longer to get going and less time to be impressed.

A club: DECA, FBLA, or a business class

Give them a real business instead of a card. Have them walk a shopping center — Market Street, Hughes Landing, a strip center on Rayford Road — count what they can actually observe, and build their own card. Observation is harder than analysis and far more useful.

THE CONNECTION

What this has to do with The Aperture Method

Not everything in a session needs to reference your firm, and most of it should not. But if a student or a teacher asks what the grown-up version looks like, here is the honest answer — the kid version is not a simplification of the real thing. It is the same thing with smaller numbers.

In this classroom	In the real engagement	The component
Five lenses on a whiteboard	A seven-lens diagnostic, evidence-tested against what management believes	Aperture Insights™
"What is left after you pay for everything?"	A profit map by product, location and segment, reconciled to the P&L	Aperture Analytics™
"Where are you, and who walks past?"	Trade-area, drive-time and market-penetration analysis	Aperture Intelligence™
"Name ONE bottleneck"	An opportunity matrix and a one-page focus plan — Now, Next, Later	Aperture Compass™
"Did the fix actually work?"	A live scoreboard and a monthly signal brief	Aperture Atlas™

Look · Count · Choose · Watch

Four words, and they are the whole job at any scale. Students do the first two in this session.

If you have five spare seconds at the close, say that out loud. It gives the hour a shape they can carry.

BEFORE YOU GO

Materials checklist

Item	How many	Note
Business cards	One per team	Print single-sided. Cardstock if you can.
Student worksheets	One per student	Not one per team. Every student writes.
Answer key	One, for you	Do not leave it on the table.
Whiteboard markers	Two colours	Assume the room's markers are dead. They are.
A timer	One	Your phone, visible, out loud. It changes the pace of the room.
Nothing else	—	No slides required. Slides make you talk.

Ten minutes before

- Write the five lenses on the board. Leave them up all hour.
- Ask the teacher: how do they normally split this class into groups? Use their system, not yours.
- Ask the teacher for the names of two students who will talk. You will need them in the first five minutes.
- Put the cards face down on the desks before students arrive. Curiosity is free.